

» CHAMPIONS TROPHY PREVIEW

PAKISTAN



Injuries and form a **big worry**

Fakhar Zaman's return after a fallout with the PCB in 2024 is a **big positive** and adds depth to the batting.

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The last time the Champions Trophy was played in 2017, Pakistan clinched the title by defeating India in the final. Few expected it to go all the way, but the team rode on fine performances and *jigar* (sheer determination) – as the then captain Sarfaraz Ahmed later highlighted – to create history.

Eight years on, Pakistan returns as defending champion and host.

However, it will not enjoy a complete home advantage, as its marquee fixture against India will be played at a neutral venue in Dubai.

Pakistan has named a strong squad on paper, but Saim Ayub's injury has unsettled the team combination, shifting focus back to Babar Azam and captain Mohammad Rizwan. While their recent form has raised concerns, the 50-over format could provide the platform to regain

rhythm and consistency.

Fakhar Zaman's return after a fallout with the PCB in 2024 adds depth to the batting. Asad Shafiq, a selection committee member, suggested either Babar or Saud Shakeel could open with Fakhar, depending on conditions, opposition, and strategy. "Both are capable, with Babar experienced in the role, having opened in T20Is and impressed in the Cape Town Test with two